



Title: Indonesia's Experience of Tapping Tourism: Lessons for Pakistan

Event Date: February 10, 2026

Venue: Indonesia Corner, National Library of Pakistan, Islamabad

Time: 12:30-15:00

Indonesia stands as one of the world's most diverse and attractive tourist destinations, home to over 17,000 islands, world-class heritage sites like Borobudur and Prambanan, and beautiful natural wonders from the beaches of Bali to the unique ecosystem of Komodo Island. With 13.9 million annual international visitors, Indonesia has positioned itself as a strong player for cultural and sustainable tourism in Southeast Asia. Similarly, Pakistan is also gaining recognition for its heritage and dramatic landscape, but the tourism industry is still untapped. Therefore, the Consortium for Asia Pacific & Eurasian Studies (CAPES), the Indonesian Embassy in Pakistan, and Indonesian Students Association Islamabad (PPMI) jointly organized the discussion on the topic, "Indonesia's Experience of Tapping Tourism: Lessons for Pakistan".

Delivering the keynote address, H.E. Rahmat Hindiarta Kusuma, Minister Counsellor for Information, Social & Cultural Affairs at the Indonesian Embassy of Pakistan, said that through a culture of mutual respect, dialogue, and trust, the Indonesian tourism industry has been able to encompass a diverse array of tourists and welcomes everyone from across the globe. He also highlighted that Pakistan has great tourism potential, as the tourism industry in Pakistan in 2025 amounted to US\$ 4.9 billion, and is expected to double in 2031. To promote tourism between Indonesia and Pakistan, he recommended the launch of direct flights between the two nations and boosting connectivity through CPEC. Thus, discussions like this provide a good opportunity to connect business and academic communities.

Dr. Muhammad Shoaib, Senior Vice President of CAPES, underscored that the Indonesian tourism industry presents a case study for Pakistan to showcase its culture, sites, and attract tourists from all over the world. He recommended that Pakistan should explore more tourism sites within the country, especially the marine sector, and should be able to promote cultural and heritage sites. He also reflected the goal of CAPES to enhance P2P and cross-cultural linkages, as through the exchange of knowledge and mutual experiences, both countries can learn from each other.

Ali Rashah Hussein, Campus Head and Director of COTHM Online Business School, noted that to promote tourism, each country's norms, values, and culture need to be understood. To promote the tourism sector in Pakistan, the country should follow a LEGO strategy, i.e., understand what strategies best fits from Indonesia in Pakistan and vice versa. The untapped tourism potential of the country should be explored, and the concept of innovative hospitality should be adopted.



Dr. Irram Waheed, Assistant Professor at SMME, NUST, underlined that Indonesia and Pakistan share multiple common factors, including the potential for halal tourism and rich Islamic heritage. Both countries should work on arranging direct flights, easing visa policies, and participating in the ASEAN Gateway initiative to promote tourism. Furthermore, student exchanges should not only focus on academic exchanges but also on excursion and tourism-based exchanges. These can be the basis of further collaborations between the students and the general public of both countries.

Ahmad Jazuli, a student at the Islamic International University in Islamabad, shared his personal experience of travelling to different sites in Pakistan, highlighting the differences in urban and rural areas. He praised Pakistan for having diverse tourist sites but suggested that the Pakistani government should work on infrastructure and services to realize the full potential of the tourism sector.

